



Before Choice, There Must Be Access



I used to think the food challenge was mostly about helping people choose better.

Cleaner labels. Better ingredients. More awareness.

After visiting government schools in Kangra, Himachal Pradesh through Bodhi Greens Foundation, I realised that for many children, the conversation starts far earlier than choice.

It starts with access.

When I asked students about vegetables, many could name them all.

But when I asked how often they ate them, the answers became quieter.





Teachers shared that some younger children occasionally faint in school because they arrive without having eaten. For many students, the Mid-Day Meal is not just part of the school day. It is the meal they depend on most. What was difficult to sit with was this: many of these children come from farming families, yet nutritious food is still not assured at home.



Vegetables, fruits, and food diversity are often missing from daily meals.



According to NFHS-5, nearly half of India's adolescent girls are anaemic. In schools, those numbers show up as tiredness, difficulty concentrating, missed classes, and lost confidence.

And yet, what stayed with me most was not the challenge.





It was the potential.

The curiosity in the room.

The questions.

The willingness to learn.

The gap is not ability.

The gap is opportunity.

And sometimes, opportunity
begins with something as
simple as a nutritious meal.

